# Erika: Poems of the Holocaust

## By William Heyen

### Stories (pg 5)

What if the world is filled with stories? --

we hear only a few, live fewer,

and most that we live or hear

solve nothing, lead nowhere . . . .

## INTRODUCTION

*It is the stories that bring history to life. The more we liste, the more understand. When we are able to personalize random facts and statistics, history becomes human, becomes real.*

*Martin Niemöller was a prominent Protestant pastor who emerged as an outspoken public foe of Adolf Hitler. He spent the last seven years of Nazi rule in concentration camps. He penned the following lines just after the Holocaust, and argued against apathy—and for the moral connectedness of all people.*

*"First they came for the Socialists, and I did not speak out— Because I was not a Socialist. Then they came for the Trade Unionists, and I did not speak out— Because I was not a Trade Unionist. Then they came for the Jews, and I did not speak out— Because I was not a Jew. Then they came for me—and there was no one left to speak for me."*

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### Riddle (pg 36-37)

From Belsen a crate of gold teeth,

from Dachau a mountain of shoes,

from Auschwitz a skin lampshade

Who killed the Jews?

Not I, cries the typist,

not I, cries the engineer,

not I, cries Adolf Eichmann,

Not I, cries Albert Speer.

David Nova swallowed gas,

Hyman Abrahms was beaten and starved.

Some men signed their papers,

and some stood guard,

and some herded them in,

And some dropped the pellets,

and some spread the ashes,

and some hosed the walls,

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Some smelled the smoke,
some just heard the news.
Were they Germans? Were they Nazis?
Were they human? Who killed the Jews?

The stars will remember the gold,
the sun will remember the shoes,
the moon will remember the skin.
But who killed the Jews?

**Three Relations (Sachsenhausen, 1944)**
**(pg 22-23)**

The small stone house stands by itself,
thirty meters long, thirty meters wide,
five meters high. Two small windows
with heavy bars. A lawn in front,
And a wooden shack, where people undress,
to shower, they think.
They walk into the stone house.

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Concrete floor and no furniture.
Maybe two hundred nozzles stick out.
The two windows and door lined with rubber.
It's a shower, all right, but gas comes out
and twists their bodies into awful shapes
Gas does not put them quietly to sleep.
Their flesh is torn with their own or others' teeth.

Their bodies were bluish red.
We dragged them out of the gas house
by hair and ears and feet
and threw them on a flat wagon
Each wagon had room for seventy bodies.
We drove the load to the crematorium.
We stacked them at the entrance

Flesh does not burn like wood --
it takes a long time to burn humans.

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## Simple Truths (pg 107-110)

When a man has grown a body,
a body to carry with him
through nature for as long as he can,
when this body is taken from him
by other men and women who happen to be,
this  time, in uniform,
Then it is clear he has experienced
an act of barbarism,

And when a man has a wife,
a wife to love for as long as he lives,
When this wife if marked with a yellow star
and driven into a chamber she will never leave alive,
then this is murder,
so much is clear.
and when a woman has hair,
when her hair is shorn and her scalp bleeds,
when a woman has  children,
Children to love for as long as she lives,

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when the children are taken from her,
When a man and his wife and their children
Are put to death in a chamber of gas,
or with pistols at close range, or are starved,
or beaten, or injected by the thousands,
Or ripped apart, by the thousands, by the millions,

it is clear that where we are
is Europe, in our century, during the years
from nineteen-hundred and thirty-five
to nineteen-hundred and  forty-five
after the death of Jesus, who spoke of a different
order,
but whose father, who is our father,
If he is our father,
If we must speak of him as father,
Watched, and witnessed, and knew,

And when we remember,
When we touch the skin of our own bodies,
When we open our eyes into dream

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or within the morning shine of sunlight
and remember what was taken
from these men, from these women,
from these children gassed and starved
and beaten and thrown against walls
and made to walk the valley
of knives and icepicks and otherwise
exterminated in ways appearing to us almost
beyond even the maniacal human imagination,
Then it is clear that this is the German Reich<
During approximately ten tears of our lord's time,

and when we read a book of these things,
when we hear the names of the camps,
when we see the films of the bulldozed dead
or the film of one boy struck on the head
with a club in the hands
of a German doctor who will wait
some days for the boy's skull to knit, and will enter
the time in his ledger, and then
take up the club to strike the boy again,

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and wait some weeks for the boy's skull to knit,
and enter the time in his ledger again<
and strike the boy again,
and so on, until the boy, who,
at the end of the film of his life
can hardly stagger forward toward the doctor,
does die, and the doctor
enters exactly the time of the boy's death in his
ledger,

when we read these things or see them,
then it is clear to us that this
happened, and within the lord's allowance, this
work of his minions, his poor
vicious dumb German victims twisted
into the swastika shapes of trees struck by lightning
on this his earth, if he is our father,
if we must speak of him in this way,
this presence above us, within us, this
mover, this first cause, this spirit, this
curse, this bloodstream and brain-current, this

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unfathomable oceanic ignorance of ourselves, this is
automatic electric Aryan swerve, this

fortune that you and I were not the victims this
luck that you and I were not the murderers, this
sense that you and I are clean and understand, this
stupidity that gives him breath, gives him life
as we kill them all, as we killed them all.

## TRANSITION

*Although the Holocaust occurred more than 50 years ago, once again history seems to be repeating itself. The Syrian crisis finds millions of Syrian mothers and children attempting to flee their country due to violent civil war. Those who are not fortunate enough to get out of the country face air raids, bombings, constant terrorist attacks and are even at risk of losing their lives. The Jewish children of the Holocaust and the Syrian children of today face a world with too much apathy.*

*First they came for the Muslims . . . . and I did not speak out . . . in fact I closed my door . . . because I was not a Muslim . . .*

*After the Holocaust, the world said "Never Again" – Well, never is here and it's happening again in Syria. Are you willing to be held accountable for our silence and inaction during the worst humanitarian crisis of our time?*

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## The Children (pg 116 – 118)

*I do not think we can save them.*
I remember, within my dream, repeating
*I do not think we can save them.*
but our cars follow one another
over cobblestones. Our dim
Headlamps, yellow in fog, brush past,
at the center of a market square,
its cathedral's great arched doors.
I know, now, this is a city
in Germany, two years
after the Crystal Night. I think ahead
to the hospital, the children.
*I do not think we can save them.*
Inside this dream,
in a crystal dashboard vase,
one long-stemmed rose unfolds
strata of soft red light.
Its petals fall, tears, small
flames. I cup my palm to hold them,

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and my palm fills to its brim,
will overflow.
Is this the secret, then? . . .
Now I must spill the petal light, and drive.

We are here, in front of the hospital,
our engines murmuring. Inside,
I carry a child under each arm,
Down stairs, out to my car.
One's right eyeball hangs on its cheek
on threads of nerve and tendon
but h e s till smiles, and I love him.
The other has lost her chin --
I can see straight down her throat
to where her heart beats
black-red, black-red.
*I do not think we can save them.*

I am the last driver in this procession.
Many children huddle in my car.
We have left the city. Our lights

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tunnel the fog beneath arches of linden,
toward Bremerhaven, toward
the western shore..
*I do not think we can save them.*
This time, at the thoughts, lights
whirl in my mirror, intense
fear, and the screams of sirens.
I begin to cry, for myself, for the children.
A voice in my dream says
*this was the midnight you were born. . .*

Later, something brutal happened, of course,
but as to this life I had to, I woke,
and cannot, or will not, remember.
But the children, of course, were murdered,
their graves lost, their names lost,
Even those two faces lost to me. Still,
this morning, inside the engine of my body,
for once, as I wept and breathed deep,
relief, waves of relief, as though the dreamed
rose would spill its petals forever.

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I prayed thanks. For one night, at least,

I tried to save the children

to keep them safe in my own body,

and knew I would again. Amen.

## SOURCE INFORMATION

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